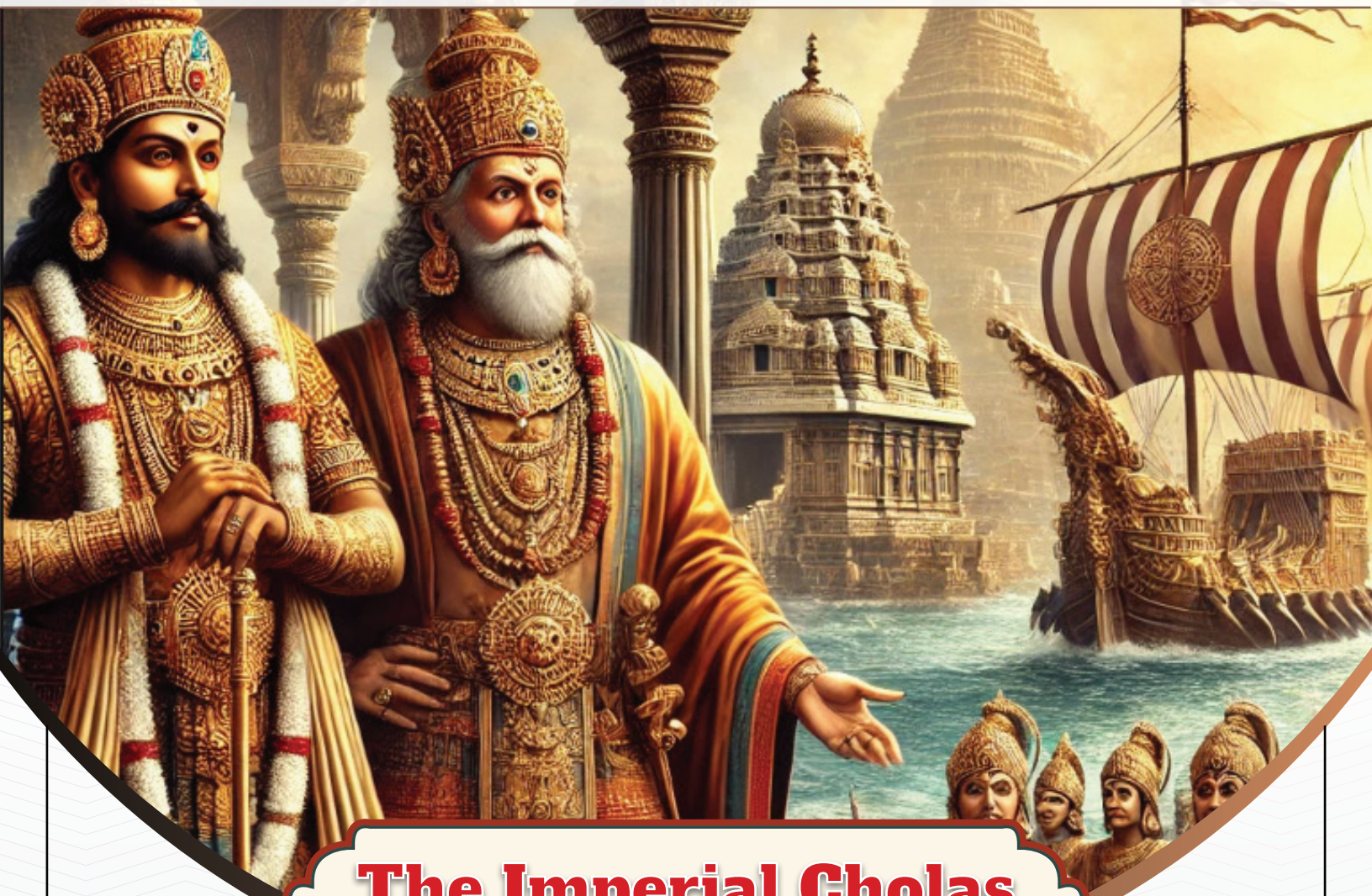




The Imperial Cholas **(850 – 1279 AD)** **Part - 2**

Economic Prosperity During the Chola Period

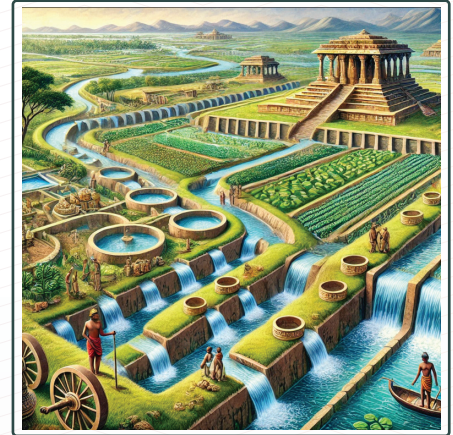
Agricultural Expansion

- Surplus grain production fueled economic growth.
- Major Agricultural Communities:
 - Valangai – Dominant landowning cultivators.
 - Kudi Neekki – Local peasant farmers.



Irrigation System

- **Kallanai Dam** (originally built by the Early Cholas) was improved for better water management.
- **Vativaykkal System** – Network of irrigation canals in the Kaveri delta:
 - **Vati** – Drainage channels (north-south).
 - **Vaykkal** – Supply channels (east-west).
- **Canal Ownership:**
 - **Ur-vaykkal** – Jointly owned by local landowners.
 - **Nattu-vaykkal** – Managed at the Nadu (regional) level.



Trade and Commerce in the Chola Empire

Trade flourished under the Cholas with the development of **Peruvazhis** (major trunk roads) and merchant guilds. The **silk-weaving industry in Kanchipuram** thrived, with weavers organizing into guilds and forming their own residential colonies.

Merchant & Artisan Guilds in the Chola Empire

- **Ayyavole 500 (Ainutruvar) & Manigramam** – Powerful trade guilds engaged in regional and international commerce.
- **Idangai Guilds** – Artisan and merchant groups involved in large-scale production.
- **Nagaram** – Local trade guilds in commercial hubs like Kanchipuram and Mamallapuram.



Trading Communities

- **Gavundas** – Landowning and trading class.
- **Anjuvannam** – Maritime traders, including Jews, Christians, and Muslims.
- **Valanjiyar** – Long-distance traders specializing in overseas trade.

Foreign Trade

- The Cholas maintained strong commercial ties with **China, Sumatra, Java, and Arabia**.
- Arabian horses were imported in large numbers to strengthen the cavalry.



Social Structure of the Chola Empire

Chola society was structured based on the **Varnashrama** system, with **Valangai (right-hand castes)** and **Idangai (left-hand castes)** divisions. **Land ownership determined social status:**

- **1. Brahmadeya-kilavars** – Brahmin landowners in tax-exempt Brahmadeya villages (highest status).
- **2. Vellanvagai Landowners** – Controlled agricultural lands and held administrative power.
- **3. Ulukudi (Tenant Cultivators)** – Worked under landowners but lacked ownership rights.



Laborers and Slaves

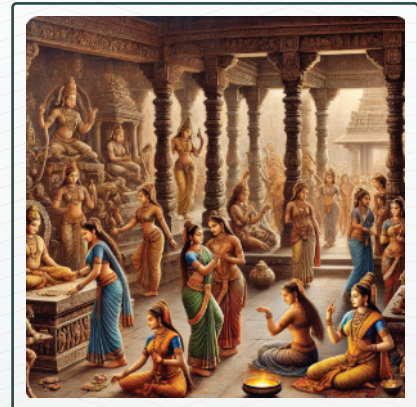
- **Paniceymakkal** – Landless laborers who worked on farms and public projects.
- **Adimaigal** – Slaves, often captives from wars or debt-bonded laborers.

Status of Women

- Women had **limited rights**, but some engaged in **temple administration** and patronized art.

Prevalent Social Practices:

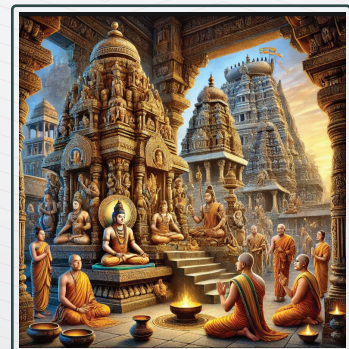
- **Sati** – Practiced among royalty and elite classes.
- **Devadasi System** – Women dedicated to temple service as dancers and musicians.
- Despite social constraints, **some women played active roles in religious and cultural affairs.**



Religion in the Chola Empire

The Cholas were devout **Shaivites** but also patronized **Vaishnavism** and **Buddhism**.

- **Vaishnavism Flourished**, promoted by **Alvar saints**.
- **Nayanars (Shaivite saints)** played a key role in spreading Shaivism.



Art and Architecture

Temple Architecture

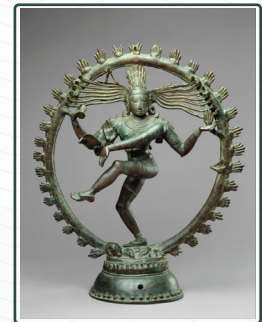
The Cholas excelled in **Dravidian-style temple architecture**, constructing grand temples:

- **1. Brihadeshvara Temple, Thanjavur** – Built by **Rajaraja I**.
- **2. Gangaikonda Cholapuram Temple** – Erected by **Rajendra I** to commemorate his northern victories.
- **3. Airavatesvara Temple, Darasuram** – Built by **Rajaraja II**, renowned for its intricate sculptures.



Bronze Sculptures

- Chola bronze **lost-wax sculptures** are considered masterpieces of Indian art.
- The most famous icon is **Nataraja (Shiva in cosmic dance)**, symbolizing creation and destruction.



Literature

- **Tamil literature thrived**, with major works such as:
 - **Thevaram** – Shaivite devotional hymns by Nayanmars (Appar, Sambandar, Sundarar).
 - **Periyapuranam** – A biography of the **63 Nayanmars**, compiled by **Sekkizhar** in the 12th century.
 - Kamban wrote Ramavataram which is the translation of Ramayana and called Kamba Ramayanam.



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